

## Reading Analytically: The Importance of Annotation or “Talking to the Text”

**QUESTION:** Have you ever started reading something, particularly for school, and found yourself a few paragraphs/pages in with NO IDEA what you just read? Have you re-read the SAME WORDS multiple times only to completely forget it all?

It happens to everyone and it's called PASSIVE READING. We forget what we read when we are distracted, tired, or simply unfocused. Sometimes we just want to read to get to the *end of the thing*, but reading this way is more work in the end.

**ACTIVE READING** is the best way to make the most of any reading assignment and in the Humanities, help you *read analytically*.

Annotation or “talking to the text” is a form of **active reading** that helps readers retain information and start critically thinking about the material. It also helps us **WORK SMARTER rather than harder**.

So what exactly is annotation? Annotation is simply TAKING NOTES as you read the text. These notes include highlighting ideas and vocabulary, asking questions and summarizing. Ideally, we take notes DIRECTLY ON THE TEXT, but it can also mean taking notes in a notebook or on sticky notes. Electronic files are an option as well, but **the MANUAL STIMULATION of writing notes helps with retention and processing**. Either way, in order to get the most out of annotation, we must have some kind of notes INSIDE THE BOOK or ON the digital version of the text.

**QUESTION:** How does annotation help us work smarter? Annotation creates visual and verbal stimulation of the BRAIN! It activates something called METACOGNITION. By “talking to the text” instead of just reading through, we signal to the brain that this is information we want to hang on to for a while. We remember what we THINK about, and we think about what we question. So METACOGNITION is “knowing about knowing.” Think about that for a minute...then annotate this page!

### ANNOTATE IT! 6 EASY STEPS TO ANNOTATION or: “How to talk to the text & activate your brain!”

1. **Circle and define** unknown words and phrases
2. **Summarize** each section
3. **Highlight** or underline key phrases
4. **Identify patterns** (repeated words, related ideas, opposing ideas, “weird” things that stand out)
5. **Identify theme(s)** using complete sentences, not just a word
6. **Ask questions** (at least 3) including “What do I think these patterns mean?”